



CAGE Screen

Developer: J. Ewing

Overview

The CAGE Screen is a screening tool for identifying potentially problematic alcohol use among adolescents over age 16 and adults. It is a quick and easy to remember assessment often used in primary care or other general settings. CAGE is a mnemonic acronym of the first letter of key words in the four screening questions. The CAGE has also been adapted to include assessment of alcohol AND drug use (CAGE-AID).

Focus Area

Substance Use

Purpose

Screening/Initial Evaluation

Reporter

Student
Clinician

Versions

Student, 4 items (for ages 16+)
Clinician, 4 items (for ages 16+)

Subscales

Not Available

Sample Items

- ♦ Have you ever felt you needed to **Cut down** on your drinking?
- ♦ Have people **Annoyed** you by criticizing your drinking?
- ♦ Have you ever felt bad or **Guilty** about your drinking?
- ♦ Have you ever had a drink first thing in the morning to steady your nerves or get rid of a hangover (**Eye opener**)?

Response Options

No
Yes

Estimated Completion Time

One minute

Languages

English

Cost

Free

Access the measures:

[CAGE Screen](#)

[CAGE-AID](#)

[CAGE and CAGE-AID](#)



Scoring

CAGE Screen		CAGE-AID																																								
Possible range	0-4																																									
Item scores	No (0) to Yes (1)																																									
Administration & scoring rules	To use the CAGE or CAGE-AID for screening: ➤ Use as a self-report tool or it can be clinician-administered ◆ Rate symptoms present in the past year ◆ Sum all “Yes” responses ◆ Use the interpretation information below and follow recommendations regarding follow-up for additional assessment if indicated																																									
Interpretation	➤ A score of 1 suggests the individual is at risk for problems with alcohol/drug use. ➤ A score of 2 suggests a current problem with alcohol/drug use. ➤ A score of 3 or more suggests dependence with alcohol/drug use (until ruled out). <table border="1"><tr><th colspan="5">LIKELIHOOD RATIOS WITH CAGE SCORES IN 821 GENERAL MEDICAL OUTPATIENTS</th></tr><tr><td colspan="5">DG Buchsbaum, RG Buchanan, RM Centor, SH Schnoll, MJ Lawton. Screening for alcohol abuse using CAGE scores and likelihood ratios. <i>Annals of Internal Medicine</i> 1991 115: 774-7.</td></tr><tr><th>CAGE Score</th><th>Alcoholic</th><th>Non-alcoholic</th><th>Likelihood ratio</th><th>Probability of abuse or dependence</th></tr><tr><td>0</td><td>33</td><td>428</td><td>0.14</td><td>7%</td></tr><tr><td>1</td><td>45</td><td>54</td><td>1.50</td><td>46%</td></tr><tr><td>2</td><td>86</td><td>34</td><td>4.50</td><td>72%</td></tr><tr><td>3</td><td>74</td><td>10</td><td>13.00</td><td>88%</td></tr><tr><td>4</td><td>56</td><td>1</td><td>100.00</td><td>98%</td></tr></table> The CAGE works best in men and less well in women and minority populations. The item regarding using alcohol or drug use as an “eye opener” is an unlikely pattern of alcohol or drug use in adolescents, and thus, is not appropriately targeted at this population. For an adolescent specific alcohol use screener to use with students as young as 12 years old, please see the CRAFFT.		LIKELIHOOD RATIOS WITH CAGE SCORES IN 821 GENERAL MEDICAL OUTPATIENTS					DG Buchsbaum, RG Buchanan, RM Centor, SH Schnoll, MJ Lawton. Screening for alcohol abuse using CAGE scores and likelihood ratios. <i>Annals of Internal Medicine</i> 1991 115: 774-7.					CAGE Score	Alcoholic	Non-alcoholic	Likelihood ratio	Probability of abuse or dependence	0	33	428	0.14	7%	1	45	54	1.50	46%	2	86	34	4.50	72%	3	74	10	13.00	88%	4	56	1	100.00	98%
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